# Karukku

## Summary

Chapter 1

Bama starts off the first chapter in the novel with a detailed description of her village. She says that before she talks about the castes and communities within the village, she has plenty to say about the village.

She starts off with the mountain range in the Western Ghats - that surround the village. These mountains have names like the Marakkaa Puuchi Malai which is named after a rock face that looks exactly like a marakkaal paddy measure. Another peak is called Perumaara after the Perumaal Saami temple that is located on the mountain. Vattala Vitthaam Paara is a peak that is named as such after Vattala Vittha Naicker who owns the fields on it. Vannaan Paara is the one where there is a tank at the top where the boys come to wash their clothes. Nari Paara used to be crowded with foxes in the olden days.

She digresses to talk about the occupation and caste of the villagers. Most of them are agricultural labourers, who go up to the woods in the mountains to gather firewood and sell it in times where work in the fields is not feasible. However, people from upper castes do not such problems of finding work in the fields as they own fields with boundaries, wells and properly installed pump-sets. These people work their land throughout the year and hence, eat well and live under a good roof. Agriculture, in this area, is aided by the rushing, gushing water of the rainy season during which the lakes and ponds fill up and the village becomes even more green and beautiful.

She goes into details about the ponds that surround their street and their names and origins. When it rained heavily, they pulled up hatches to the canals feeding the lake to let the water through. Fish was caught in earthen pots that were placed where the water flowed through as the streets overflowed with all sorts of fish like Keluti, Ayirai, Viraal and more. In their streets however curries were cooked out of Silebi kendai and Paambu kendai. These were the ones that people from lower castes could afford. The upper caste ate all kinds of others that were much pricier.

She paints a picture of the post-rainy season when the pond was full and people would sit under the banyan tree shade and talk as a cool, fresh breeze would blow.

The leaping fish glinting in the sunlight, little boys skipping stones into the ponds, people catching fish using earthworms from rubbish heaps as bait, the fish then roasted on the shore, buffaloes bathing pleasurably these are the stark, beautiful images that Bama employs to paint a portrait of her village.

The Muniappasaami temple is located in a place called Mandavam with a ruined pillared structure towards the west of the village, where people go to find a living. Once a year, a festival is held where offerings are made. Once, a man called Bondan robbed these offerings and escaped with the temple bell.

From that day onwards, it is said that Muniyaandi from the Muniyaandi temple would walk the streets at night, threatening to set things on fire if Bondan did not return his offerings to him. Bondan conceded and Muniyaandi returned, never to be back again.

She digresses at this point, to talk about Bondan, whose main preoccupation was burglary and selling the robbed goods, which are usually limes, coconuts and mangoes. Once when climbing a coconut tree he encountered an evil demon spirit. Another incident had taken place where Bondan had to jump into a well with his sack of mangoes as the caretaker was approaching. However, he encountered a cobra, which he successfully kept at bay till the watchman left.

Another time, when he was bit by a cobra on his toe he struck a match, burned the spot and cut off his toe. He was also said to have survived an Ayyangaatchi troupe - a group of peys.

The Naicker community owned most of the land in the village. These fields had their own names, like Olivizhikkaadu, which was an open field where anything said out loud, echoed.

There is a small terminus bus-stand at the entrance to the village. Beyond which there is a stream.

Around this, there are small settlements like Odapatti where the Nadars - who climb palm trees - live, and settlements of the Koravar who sweep streets and Chakkiliyar that work with leathers. Other settlements are that of Kusavar who make earthen pots, Palla and Paraya. To the east of the village lies a cemetery next to which is

where Bama's community lived. The Naicker and the Udaiyaar communities have each settlements for themselves too.

While those from the upper caste never stepped foot in the part of the village where people from the lower castes lived, the latter had to occasionally visit the former on account of work. The upper caste streets had all the infrastructural facilities such as the post office, the panchayat boards, the schools, the church, the big shops, etc.
The part where Bama's community lived was made up of five streets - South Street, Middle Street, North Street, East Street and Olatharapatti Street. Most of the houses in the rows had Palmyra thatched roofs. Houses that were made of lime and plaster were the houses of government employees.
When the church bell struck at twelve in the noon, children who wandered bare-bottomed would rush off for their free meals with plates in their hands.
It is at five in the afternoon that the streets would be crowded with the hustle and bustle of both men and women, with noise and fuss erupting at the single water-pump in the area. These silly quarrels added to the charm of the place.

Once, a woman called Gnanappu had left her bucket with the intention to hold her place in the queue at the water-pump and left to run other errands. When she returned someone had placed her bucket at the end of the line. This infuriated her and she kept arguing referring to her bucket as "bycket" which made everyone laugh.
A peculiar thing about these streets were the names that were given to people. A really short-tempered child was named Munkovam. A lady was known as Midday Masala as one day she ground some masala during midday and made curry. There was a child named Murugan-spring pig as the pigs that wandered around Murugan's spring were well-fed and plump like the child. A woman who leaked all over her legs when urinating was called Kazhinja - Leaky. A girl who couldn't swim but could only float was named Medenda - Floater.

A man named Kaaman, whose real name was Maria-Lourdes, lived near their house. However, no one knew the origin of the nickname even though it has stuck since his childhood. He never really had a job but ran menial errands for other people. However, out of the blue, he suddenly started going to work regularly in his khaki uniform.

The famous Nallathanga temple is located in a village northwards called Archanaavaraam. In the old days, it is said that there were two people in this village an older brother and his sister. He married her off to someone from Maanaamarutai. He also got married to Muuli Alangari who was a vain and conceited woman who never allowed near to near husband.

Soon after, a famine struck Maanaamarutai where Nallathangaal gave birth to seven children one after the other. After the birth of each one she would send a letter to her brother which Muuli Alangari would intercept and burn. One day, a letter containing the news about the famine reached her brother who immediately set out to bring her home. However upon returning, she found that all the doors to the house were closed. When she finally entered the house, her children, hungry and weary from the trip, immediately started devouring food. Seeing this infuriated Muuli Alangaari who threw Nallathangaal out of the house. An extremely distraught Nallathangaal threw all her children into the well. However when the last one escaped to a shepherd he told him everything. Nallathangaal found him too and threw him in the well and jumped in herself. Upon returning from the market, the elder brother found no one and enquired to his wife who lied and said they didn't turn up. Upon searching everywhere, the brother gets the whole true story from the shepherd and kills Muuli by throwing her in the burning kiln. He then proceeded to build statues of Nallathangaal and her seven children and the shepherd and placed them in a shrine.

**Chapter 2**

By the time she was in third grade, Bama had experienced untouchability even though she hadn't heard it being spoken about. She goes on to narrate a few incidents where untouchability had touched her life.

It took Bama almost an hour to get home from school which is really only a ten minute journey. The streets and the marketplace fascinated her with its snake charmers, cyclists, hunter-gypsies and what not. Or sometimes, it was a political party that would set up a stage and host a street play or a puppet show. There were also coffee clubs in the bazaar that often caught Bama's attention; or the almond tree with its benevolent shades. According to the season there would be all kinds of fruits and veggies or fried snacks and iced lollies.